

Where Does Morality Come From? A Historical Tour of Ethical Theories

An original lesson plan inspired by **Gregory Sadler's** *Ethics: A Free Online Course* (Open Culture). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Open Culture or Gregory Sadler. Explore the original course: <https://www.openculture.com/ethics-a-free-course>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 10-12	50 minutes	Ethics

“Over roughly 2,500 years, philosophers have located the source of morality in different places — the gods, reason, character, consequences, relationships of care. Which starting point makes the most sense to you, and why?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Identify at least four distinct historical approaches to ethics: divine command/natural law, virtue ethics, deontology, and utilitarianism (with an optional fifth, the ethics of care).
- Explain, for each approach, what it treats as the fundamental source or standard of moral rightness.
- Explain how at least one later theory developed specifically as a reaction against an earlier one.

Materials Needed

- Four or five “station” handouts, each with a short primary-source excerpt and 2–3 framing questions (suggested: Aquinas or the Euthyphro on divine command/natural law; a short passage from Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics* on virtue; a passage from Kant's *Groundwork*; a passage from Mill's *Utilitarianism*)
- A blank timeline strip (poster paper or a printed handout) for the mapping activity
- Timer for station rotations

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Timeline Guess

8 min

Write the names “Aristotle,” “Aquinas,” “Kant,” and “Mill” on the board out of order and ask students to guess, without any hints, which century each lived in and place them on a rough timeline. Reveal the actual dates. This sets up the framing for the day: each thinker was responding to a different intellectual moment, not working in isolation.

Station Rotation

24 min

Set up 4 stations (or 5 with care ethics), each with a short excerpt and framing questions: (1) Divine command/natural law — is something good because God commands it, or does God command it because it's good? (2) Virtue ethics — what kind of person should you be, rather than what rule should you follow? (3) Deontology — what makes an act right regardless of its consequences? (4) Utilitarianism — what makes the consequences of an act good or bad? Groups spend 5–6 minutes per station reading the excerpt and answering the framing questions in writing before rotating.

Building the Timeline

12 min

As a whole class, place each theory on the shared timeline and connect it with an arrow to whichever earlier theory it was most directly reacting against (for instance: Kant's insistence on duty regardless of consequences as a reaction against purely outcome-based reasoning; Mill's utilitarianism as an attempt to make ethics scientific and impartial rather than tied to religious authority). Ask groups to justify their proposed connections using specific lines from the excerpts.

Closure: Quick Poll

6 min

Poll the class by show of hands: which of the four (or five) approaches feels closest to how you actually reason about right and wrong in everyday life? Ask one or two students from each camp to explain their choice in one sentence.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Do you think one of these four approaches is simply correct, or do different situations call for different kinds of moral reasoning?
- 2 Virtue ethics asks “what would a good person do?” — is that a useful guide, or does it just push the question back a step to “what makes someone good?”
- 3 Kant says an act's moral worth depends on the motive behind it, not its results — does that seem right, or does it let good intentions off the hook for bad outcomes?
- 4 If ethics of care emphasizes relationships and context over universal rules, can it still give guidance in cases involving strangers we have no relationship with?

Assessment

Students write a short paragraph identifying which historical approach they find most convincing and explaining, using specific concepts from that station's excerpt, why it beats at least one rival approach on a case of their choosing.

Extension Activity

Assign students to find a modern ethical debate (in business, medicine, or technology) and identify which of the four historical frameworks a specific argument in that debate is implicitly using, even if the framework is never



named.

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